

Built for the long haul, born for the big moment

Mohammed Siraj bowled more deliveries than anyone in the series, but **with stamina came skill** — his inch-perfect yorker sealed India's narrowest-ever Test win and cemented his place as more than just a workhorse.

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Fast bowling is a precise art, and a surfeit of it can blunt the skill and its efficacy. Fast bowling is also a taxing vocation, and overindulgence can break the human will and body.

But then Mohammed Siraj still bounds in, bowling his 1113th delivery on his 25th day of cricket on a tour lasting a month and a half, and conjures his fifth fastest ball of the entire series, clocked at 143 kmph. **It is a low full toss, only his second of a match in which he has sent down 279 deliveries, and it flattens the off-stump to give India the narrowest win in its existence as a Test-playing nation.**

At a time when the exigencies of multiple

formats have made managing workloads a priority for pace bowlers, the ever-present Siraj hasn't been earmarked for that luxury. Since his debut in December 2020, no Indian has featured in as many Tests as Siraj's 41. In the recently concluded drawn Test series, no bowler surpassed his gruelling tally of 185.3 overs, and the only other bowler who sent down more than 1,000 deliveries — Chris Woakes — wasn't half as effective.

His 30.1 overs were the fifth-most by an Indian pacer in the fourth innings of a Test, and Siraj is the only one to have bowled as many since 2013.

